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BEFORE THE SESSION

*The pre-work that turns a strategy session into something you
actually use.*

BY MK PARRISH · \$18

WHY THIS EXISTS

You book the call. You show up. You spend the first forty minutes explaining who you are, what you do, and why you're stuck — and then the clock runs out right as it gets good. You walk away with notes you'll never open and the same fog you came in with.

That's not a bad session. That's an unprepared one.

The clients who get the most out of a strategy session do the thinking *before* the call. They arrive knowing their own situation cold, so the hour goes to the part only an outside brain can do: seeing what they can't, and deciding what to do about it.

This is that pre-work. It's the worksheet I send before **The Session** — the questions that surface the real problem so we don't waste the hour finding it. Run it solo before any strategy call, with any consultant. Or run it on yourself when you can't afford one yet.

Set aside ninety minutes. Write your answers down — actually written, not "thought about." The friction of writing is where the clarity lives. You will be tempted to do this in your head on the drive over. Don't. The version in your head is the one you already believe; the version on paper is the one that surprises you.

PART 1 — THE IDENTITY & POSITIONING SELF-AUDIT

You can't position what you can't name. Start here. Answer fast and honest; you can refine later.

WHO I ACTUALLY AM (not the title)

I help _____ (specific people)

do/get _____ (specific outcome)

so they can _____ (the deeper why).

The thing I'm better at than most people in my field: _____

The thing people consistently come to ME for: _____

What I'm known for right now (be honest, even if you hate it): _____

What I WANT to be known for: _____

The gap between those two: _____



Worked example

I help mid-career engineers who want to move into management
do it without faking a personality they don't have,

so they can lead without burning out pretending.

Better at than most: translating technical work into plain stakes.

People come to me for: untangling messy org problems.

Known for now: "the reliable senior IC who fixes things."

Want to be known for: "the one who can run the team."

The gap: everyone trusts my hands, no one's seen me lead.

Notice what the example surfaces: the problem isn't skill, it's *perception*. That gap line is gold. It's the thing the session should be about. Find yours.

A second example (so you see the pattern)

I help women relaunching a career after a break

rewrite their story so the gap reads as range, not absence,

so they stop apologizing for the most interesting years of their life.

Better at than most: making a non-linear path sound inevitable.

People come to me for: "help me explain the gap."

Known for now: nothing yet — I'm invisible.

Want to be known for: "the relaunch person."

The gap: I have the skill and zero public proof of it.



Two different people, same structure, same payoff: the **gap line** is the brief. Whatever sits between *known for now* and *want to be known for* is the work — and almost always it's a perception or proof problem wearing a skill problem's clothes.

PART 2 — THE BRAND CLARITY QUESTIONS

These are the questions I'd ask in the first fifteen minutes — so you arrive having already answered them. Don't skip the uncomfortable ones. Those are the load-bearing ones.

The Twelve

- [] **1.** If a stranger read everything you've published, what would they think you do? Is that right?
- [] **2.** What do you say when someone asks "so what do you do?" — and do you cringe when you say it?
- [] **3.** Who are the three people whose attention or respect you actually want? Name them.
- [] **4.** What do you want them to think, feel, or do after encountering you?
- [] **5.** What's the most impressive thing you've done that you've never put anywhere?
- [] **6.** What are you tired of explaining? (That's often your real expertise.)
- [] **7.** What do you turn down? (Your no's define your brand more than your yes's.)
- [] **8.** Where are you currently being underestimated or misread?
- [] **9.** What would you say if you weren't worried about sounding arrogant?
- [] **10.** What's the one sentence you wish people understood about your work?
- [] **11.** What's working right now that you can't explain — and want to do more of on purpose?
- [] **12.** If nothing changed in twelve months, what would you most regret?

Write a real answer to each. One sentence minimum. The session moves at the speed of the answers you already have.

How to read your own answers: when you're done, circle the three that were hardest to write. Difficulty is signal — the question you most wanted to skip is usually sitting on top of the real issue. Questions 5, 8, and 9 (the hidden win, the misread, the thing you won't say) are where most breakthroughs actually live.

PART 3 — THE INNER GAME

Most sessions don't stall on strategy. They stall on the thing under the strategy — the fear you haven't said out loud, so it quietly runs the decision. Name it here, in private, before someone else is watching.

The story I tell myself about why I'm stuck: _____

The story that might be more true (the less flattering one): _____

What I'm secretly afraid is true about my work or me: _____

What it would cost me to be wrong about that fear: _____

If I fully believed I was good at this, the next move would be: _____



Worked example

Story I tell: "The market's crowded, it's hard to stand out."

More true: "I've been hiding behind 'crowded' so I don't have to pick a

Secretly afraid: that if I niche down, I'll be found out as not expert e

Cost of being wrong: another year of generic, underpriced work.

If I believed I was good: I'd raise my price and say the one thing I act



You don't have to solve this here. You just have to name it, because a fear you've named can be worked on in the room — and a fear you haven't will hijack the hour disguised as a "strategy question." The scary line is the most valuable thing on the page.

PART 4 — THE GOAL-SETTING FRAMEWORK FOR A 60-MINUTE SESSION

An hour is short. The single biggest waste is showing up with a vague goal — "I want clarity on my brand." Clarity on *what*, decided *how*, by *when*? Tighten it.

Step 1: Name the one decision

A session should produce a decision, not a feeling. Finish this sentence:

By the end of this hour, I want to have decided: _____

EXAMPLE: "...whether to reposition as a leadership coach or stay
a technical consultant — and what my LinkedIn headline becomes
either way."

If you have three things you want to decide, rank them. You'll likely only get through one well. Better one decision made than three half-touched.

Step 2: Define "useful"

This session was worth it if I leave with: _____

Pick concrete outputs, e.g.:

- A positioning statement I can actually use
- A clear next 3 actions
- A decision I've been avoiding, made
- A rewritten headline / bio / pitch



Step 3: Surface the blockers

What's actually stopping you? Name it so the session can hit it directly.

What I think is blocking me: _____

What might REALLY be blocking me (the scary version): _____

What I've already tried that didn't work: _____



Step 4: The 3-2-1 prep

3 things I want feedback on: ___, ___, ___

2 questions I'm afraid to ask out loud: ___, ___

1 outcome that would make this a no-brainer to have done: ___



Worked example — filled out

Decision: Whether to lead my consulting with "strategy" or "writing."

Useful if I leave with: one clear positioning line + my new

homepage headline + a yes/no on dropping the lowest-tier offer.

Think is blocking me: I don't know which is more marketable.

REALLY blocking me: I'm scared "writer" sounds less senior than

"strategist" and I'll be paid less.

Already tried: rewriting my bio four times, kept both, said neither.

3 for feedback: homepage headline, my pricing page, my pitch on calls

2 scary questions: Am I charging too little? Is my niche too narrow?

1 no-brainer outcome: walk away able to say what I do in one sentence.



Look at how much sharper this is than "help me with my brand." A session built on this prep can go straight to the real fear in minute two — and spend the other fifty-eight solving it.

THE PRE-SESSION CHECKLIST

Do this the morning of the call.

- ☐ All four parts filled in — written, not thought
- ☐ The one decision named in a single sentence
- ☐ "Useful" defined as concrete outputs
- ☐ The scary version of the blocker written down
- ☐ Relevant links/copy gathered in one place (bio, site, profile)
- ☐ Phone off, notes app open, somewhere you can talk freely
- ☐ One question you'd be slightly embarrassed to ask — bring it anyway

RUNNING THIS WITHOUT A SESSION

No budget for the call yet? This pre-work stands on its own — most people have never answered these questions in writing, and the act of doing it surfaces the answer more often than not. To self-facilitate: fill in all four parts, then leave it for 24 hours. Come back cold and read it as if it were a stranger's. Ask the three questions an outside brain would ask — *"What are they avoiding? What's the one sentence they keep circling? What would I tell them to do first?"* — and write those answers too. You won't fully replace the outside brain, but you'll get most of the way, and you'll know exactly what to bring when you can afford the room.

AFTER: LOCK IT IN WITHIN 24 HOURS

The session's value evaporates if you don't capture it fast. Within a day:

THE ONE DECISION I MADE: _____

THE NEXT 3 ACTIONS (with dates):

1. _____ by ____

2. _____ by ____

3. _____ by ____

THE SENTENCE I'M KEEPING: _____

WHAT I STILL NEED TO RESOLVE: _____

Then put the three actions somewhere you'll see them this week, and the kept sentence somewhere you'll see it every day. A decision you don't act on inside seven days quietly reverts to the old default. Move while it's hot.

WHEN YOU WANT THE SESSION ITSELF

This is the prep. The prep alone will move you — most people have never sat down and answered these questions in writing, and the act of doing it surfaces things on its own.

But prep isn't the session. The session is the outside brain that sees the gap you've been standing too close to read. **The Session** is 60 focused minutes where we take this pre-work and turn it into decisions you walk away ready to act on — positioning, voice, next moves.

Come prepared with this, and we skip the warm-up entirely.

Book it at **mkparrish.com**.

Do the thinking. Then let's decide.

MK PARRISH